

1976 ONWARDS

STYLE TRIBES

There have always been fashion gangs who dress in a similar way to express a shared identity – mods with their US army parkas in the 1960s, for example, or punks with ripped jeans and fishnets in the 1970s. But in the 1980s the idea of style tribes really took hold. Style tribes are groups that tend to be associated with a particular place. Members often share the same taste in music, and their way of dressing has DIY elements to set them apart from the mainstream. In the UK there were the flamboyant New Romantics who were inspired by the style of swashbuckling pirates – pop star Adam Ant and designer Vivienne Westwood were role models. In 1987 rave culture took hold in London when Acid House music and the drug MDMA (ecstasy) were transplanted from Ibiza – the smiley face became their emblem. Across the Atlantic, hip-hop and rap gave birth to new style tribes among African Americans, who wore heavy gold “bling” jewellery and pristine sportswear – such as hoodies, puffa jackets, and status trainers – and their look heavily influenced contemporary menswear across the board. Many of the pre-21st-century style-tribe looks were male-led, with women adopting feminized versions of the signature style. In the 21st century, style tribes have multiplied and include Burberry-clad chavs and Kardashian-clones, who slavishly copy the looks of the Kardashian clan that they see on reality TV and Instagram, and followers of cult labels such as Bathing Ape and Supreme.

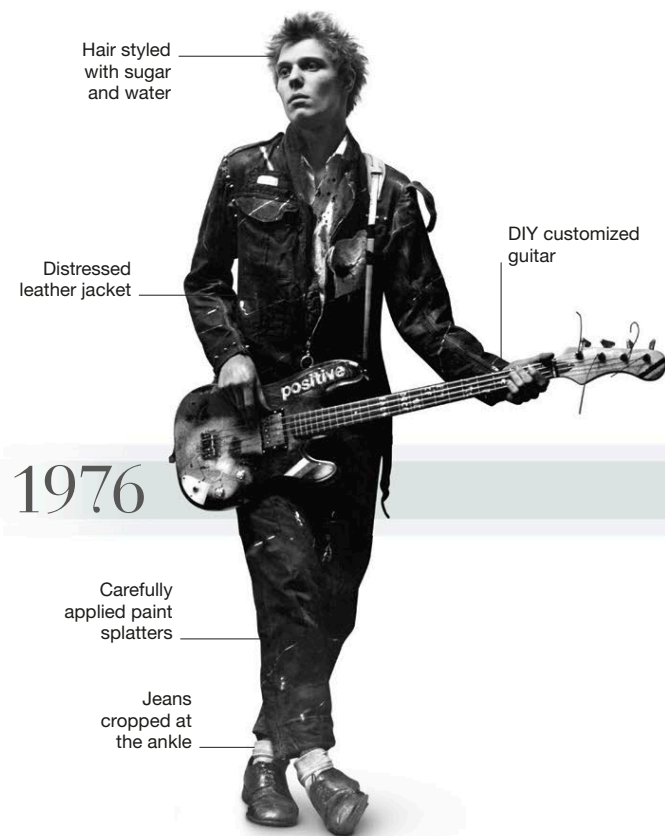
FLY GIRLS



While male rappers have held the limelight since the 1980s, a sub-culture of female rappers – known as “Fly Girls” – emerged in the boroughs of New York City in the 1970s. Their style was athletic and sexy, and their signature pieces included satin tracksuits, bodysuits, big earrings, and streetwear, such as extra-large jeans, borrowed from the boys. The first all-female crew, Sequence, debuted in 1979 and others followed, including Roxanne Shante, who wore over-sized denim jackets with chunky gold earrings, and Queen Latifah with her snapback caps and trainers. These acts paved the way for later female rap artists such as Salt N Pepa, Missy Elliott, Eve, and Stefflon Don. The word “fly” is slang for someone stylish or cool, and so the term “fly girl” was used for these sharp and sassy women.



Rasta cool The Rastafarian movement began in 1930s Jamaica but was not well known until the 1970s when Rasta Bob Marley became famous. His style influence can be seen in dreadlocks, the Rasta colours red, green, and gold, and denim on denim. Punks also picked up on elements of the style.



1976

Punk style Bassist Paul Simonson of punk band The Clash was recognized as the most stylish of the group. He helped to shape punk fashions with his attitude: you had to make people scared of you so they would leave you alone.



1984

Goth glamour The goth aesthetic came together in London club “The Batcave”. Both men and women wore clothes inspired by Victorian mourning garb and Bram Stoker’s *Dracula*, and it was not long before this movement took to the streets. Today, courtesy of Camden market, the look is still very much in evidence.